Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Shelley's "An Exhortation"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

alliteration,
antithesis,
apostrophe,
diction (word choice),
feminine (double) rhyme,
imagery,
metaphor,
meter,
rhyme scheme,
simile,
synecdoche, and
tone.

The young writer should recognize the operative presence of the simile (lines 5, 7, 11, 24) and the metaphor (lines 2, 16, 25, 26).

Shelley's comparing a poet's focus on love and fame to a chameleon feeding on "light and air" (line 1) and on "beams and wind" (line 22) underlies the comparison *in toto*, so a student's attention to this foundational comparison suffices.

Beyond the foundational comparison, the LitCritter might recognize—and it is directed commentary—that Shelley is, in all candor, a bit unkind: "poets range" (line 18); they are inconstant. Additionally, poets, if they are stained with wealth or power" (line 19)—certainly a step or two beyond "love and fame—will "grow earthly" like the chameleons, beyond the mythical (lines 12-14), actually are.

The student, noting the final three lines, as well as the poem's title, might recognize the poem to be an admonitory apostrophe in which poets, who are of a different nature from others (line 25's "[c]hildren of a sunnier star") should refuse the opportunity characterized by wealth or power and remain, not unlike the chameleon, "[s]pirits from beyond the moon" (line 26).